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modular phones go, we can only guess at what the different companies will charge for the various modules, and such guesses wouldn't take us anywhere. While it's a fact that the pricing has to be competitive, in the final analysis will it provide the consumer with enough reason to forsake the idea of getting a new phone for certain modules? That remains to be seen.

Engineering challenges

Since the modular phones haven't yet found a wider user-base, it's still only speculative how well it will function in the real world. Compatibility issues are going to be one major factor that manufacturers will have to tackle. What with the challenges we sometimes face with as simple a thing as installing an app in our smartphone, it's logical to assume that when you are fitting an entire new unit in your phone, it's bound to get tacky. Then, there are the 'fundamental' issues like the phone dropping to the ground-we all do that too often, whether we want to or not. And when the phone in question is a collection of bundled parts that hits the floor with reasonable force...scary.

Cross-compatibility

So, you buy a new module for a phone. But what's to ensure that that particular piece will gel well with modules that you may add at a later date-and we don't mean just on the visual front. This is one question that's pricking behind the forehead of many a tech-enthusiast, bringing on an itch which we cannot wait to scratch at. But to do that, we will need the future to come along. Can. Hardly. Wait!

The size

Size does matter. Nowhere is it more applicable than in the case of modular phones. Miniaturizing the modules still seems a long way off. This means that the phones would be rather clumsy to carry, if it's to have all functionalities you require.

A closer look at Google Ara

Google is the paparazzi-flanked celebrity equivalent in the tech world. Just

about anything that the company does, or doesn't do, gets reported. The good news is that the tech-mammoth does come up with interesting stuff that makes for worthy reporting. One such thing is the Google Ara.

To begin with, this will be the first phone that the company makes independently- previously, Google has given us such things as tablets and laptops though the company still persists in our mind for that search engine of theirs, dayum!

While the original plan with Ara was to modularize every component, from the screen to the camera, that is not what fate has dictated, it seems. At least, for the time being. The version of Ara that's coming out will have some of the major elements as part of the phone's frame. In addition to the screen, these include basic speakers, RAM and the processor.

The makers point out that having the key components in-built will give more space for adding more modules. Given that things like the processor may not be the first which the average user will want to replace, this makes sense.

The change in vision from an infinitely upgradable endoskeleton to one which enables hardware to be swapped means that a lot of excitement revolves around the modules that you can add. And the success of the product will certainly depend on the quality of these extra modules that Google brings out.

The company is set to bring out modules with the aid of independent developers. The market for these modules will be owned by Google and the company will take a cut of the proceedings. But in their statements to the media, the company has said it won't be a big cut. It better not be, for turning away developers wouldn't be to the benefit of Google-to reinstate, the core excitement now is around the modules they offer.

The developers which Google has roped in include heavyweights like TDK, Panasonic, Wistron, E-Ink, Harman, Sony Pictures and Samsung. A few health companies are also in the fray. Of course, Google itself will create

a few modules. Also, apparently, plenty of high-end fashion brands have also shown interest in developing modules for Ara.

What all this boils down to is that while Ara may not be a modular phone in the truest sense, for Google it brings in a new hardware ecosystem and partner platform. Something that other companies might emulate. And who is to say that it won't lead to a golden age of modular phones?

What to make of it all?

While potential exists for the modular phone-at least in theory, it's yet to be fully realized. Although many problems contribute to this, perhaps the most immediate one is that of size. If you keep on adding modules for



One modular phone to rule them all? Maybe not.

each functionality, you will end up with something far clumsier than you would like to take out in the open, let alone flaunt.

When it comes to the modular models currently available, it's more than evident that they are far from being truly modular-prototypes which approximate the idea at best, a simple leg up from swapping hardware which we practice now with the aid of a technician. But that in itself is not a bad idea, and involves significant amount of technical ingenuity. Even swapping camera modules and enhancing audio output is something that we couldn't imagine up until recently.

But until the size factor is tackled once and for all, it seems the infinitely upgradeable modular phone will remain a wishful dream. 